

RAJNATH SINGH, 72 | BJP
Minister of Defence

From shakha to ministry
Born in Chandauli district of Uttar Pradesh in 1951, Rajnath attended the village school and later Gorakhpur University. He joined the RSS in 1964 and joined politics in 1974 as a Jana Sangh member. Rising rapidly through party ranks, he was state education minister (1991-1992) and UP chief minister from 2000-2002. Later, he led the Union agriculture, transport and home ministries. He has been India's defence minister since 2019

Reforms & acquisitions
Rajnath has overseen significant acquisitions, including procurement of Rafale jets and the S-400 missile defence system. His tenure has been marked by strategic reforms, like the creation of the Chief of Defence Staff (CDS)'s position

Make in India initiative
Under his leadership, the ministry has prioritised the indigenous manufacturing of advanced equipment, such as the Light Combat Aircraft Tejas, the Dhanush howitzer and the Pinaka rocket launcher

Man for all seasons
One of the few old guard BJP leaders still active, the former UP CM has extensive contacts across parties. In a coalition government, his experience is expected to be invaluable

Minister of State



SANJAY SETH, 64 | BJP

The Long Road from Ranchi Seth is now a two-time MP from Ranchi. In 2019, he defeated Congress's Subodh Kant Sahay. As a student leader in 1992, he spent 25 days in jail after the arrest of L.K. Advani during his rath yatra

The challenges facing the government in the defence sector require careful strategic planning, followed by decisive action. In its election manifesto, the BJP promised to expand India's defence footprint across strategic locations and partner with friendly countries to protect its security interests in the Indian Ocean Region. On defence manufacturing, it has promised to continue support for start-ups, so that indigenisation can be accelerated. The other emphasis is to increase exports of Made in India defence equipment. In the 2023–24 financial year, defence exports reached a record high of Rs 21,083 crore (around $2.63 billion). The government has set up a target of Rs 35,000 crore by 2025. Continuing robust vigilance along the tense Line of Actual Control (LAC) with China is an imperative too, along with managing internal security threats, including insurgencies and terrorism. Adapting to the military/ security challenges posed by climate change—like the threat rising sea levels pose to naval bases—are on the agenda. Defence strategists point to the need to enhance the frequency of military training exercises with countries in West and Southeast Asia. The armed forces should also have a greater role in acquiring defence platforms. Visualising future battlefield environments would lead to the formulation of a capability development plan, which would direct acquisitions and indigenisation. ■

WHAT NEEDS TO BE DONE

Indigenous technology India is still one of the world's top buyers of foreign armaments. The ministry must ensure the armed forces are equipped with latest technology, while promoting self-reliance through 'Make in India' in defence manufacturing



EXPERTSPEAK
AIR MARSHAL S.B.P. SINHA (RETD)
Former Deputy Chief of Air Staff

"To bridge the technology gap in defence platforms, we must indigenise through joint ventures between Indian and foreign companies"

Border defence There is a need to further enhance border infrastructure along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the light of the continuing stand-off with China, and increase operational preparedness along the Line of Control with Pakistan

Theatre commands The unrealised joint theatre commands for effective military operations must be implemented. Experts say a pilot project is needed to put operational aspects in place

Agnipath The recruitment scheme has been a political hot potato. It must be evaluated and refined after getting feedback from the military

Cyber defence Strengthening cyber defence capabilities against cyber threats and attacks on military/ critical infrastructure